

4, Perspectives on the "Grand Chinese Case" and Why I Touch Only Lightly Upon the Ming and Qing Eras

Finally, I wish to further discuss my reflections regarding the "Grand Chinese Case" I have witnessed over these past nine hundred days and nights. I maintain that this heaven-shaking grand case concealed within Chinese history possesses genuinely immense value for all of humanity.

On one hand, this is due to its sheer protraction, immensity, severity, and concealment: over a timespan stretching one thousand four hundred years, three or four hundred million—or perhaps even more—victims perished directly or indirectly because of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度). Some suffered exceptionally gruesome deaths, yet vastly more perished in a vacuum-like silence, without emitting even a single moan. For the overwhelming majority of Chinese people, our lives possess virtually zero meaning whatsoever; the absolute terminus of one's life can be plainly seen from the very day of birth.

China's bureaucratic restoration (官僚复辟) generated a critical impact upon the entirety of human history, directly altering the overarching developmental landscape of human civilization. This broad-daylight massacre had so many eyewitnesses: initially the nomadic ethnicities of Northern China, the Koreans, the Vietnamese, and the Japanese; subsequently the Indians and the Muslims; at a later epoch, Europeans arrived at the crime scene, and finally, the Americans appeared. Among these eyewitnesses, some were themselves dragged into the case, while others conspicuously detected bizarre anomalies, yet ultimately, none of them successfully reconstructed the genesis and conclusion of the case.

Perhaps even more paramount is the sheer complexity of this momentous historical event. The renowned American Sinologist Mr. Philip Alden Kuhn (孔飞力) authored a highly famous work, *Soulstealers: The Chinese Sorcery Scare of 1768* (《叫魂：1768年中国妖术大恐慌》); from my perspective, the analytical angle of this book is exceptionally magnificent.

Based upon my comprehension of Chinese history, if the nearly seven centuries across the Sui (隋), Tang (唐), Five Dynasties (五代), and Song (宋)—a history characterized by the seesaw battle between the restoration-bureaucratic regime and **feudalism** (封建主义) ultimately culminating in the essential annihilation of the latter—were primarily political, economic, and social issues. Then, during the six centuries since the Ming (明) and Qing (清) empires, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** became utterly consolidated, **feudalism** no longer posed any threat whatsoever to it, and the development of the entire **restoration-bureaucratic society** (复辟官僚社会) plummeted entirely into a phenomenally macabre and treacherous state. People neither knew how the **restoration-bureaucratic system** was birthed, nor did they remotely understand exactly what significance its existence held, yet precisely because of it, they lived generation after generation in inexplicable terror, concurrently and ceaselessly seeking to manufacture legitimacy for its existence.

If we perceive the **restoration-bureaucratic system** as a ruthless murderer within human history, then exactly what does it look like? Is it China's supreme ruler and bureaucrats? Seemingly not. Is it the government offices (宫衙)? Seemingly not either. Is it **social consciousness** (社会意识)? Seemingly still not. This is precisely where the bizarre anomaly lies: we know explicitly that the **restoration-bureaucratic system** slaughtered hundreds of millions of commoners, but exactly how did it physically carry out the killings?

We can employ a metaphor to explain this phenomenon. Imagine an isolated society that universally worships a specific Evil God (邪神); this Evil God is precisely the **restoration-bureaucratic system**. Within the subconscious of the populace, this Evil God is more terrifying than the most malevolent creation anyone could conceivably imagine, and it sustains its existence exclusively by devouring human beings.

Predicated upon such a concept, the entire society is organized into a highly hierarchical cultic order (邪教教团). People continuously devise every conceivable method to designate others as sacrifices offered to the Evil God, thereby enabling themselves to escape. The higher one's status within this cultic order, the more power one possesses to condemn others as sacrifices, while concurrently, the number of individuals capable of turning *them* into a sacrifice proportionally decreases.

In reality, anyone who has ever lived within Chinese society will fundamentally never forget this point. It is exactly as a famous Chinese proverb dictates: *Only by enduring the most bitter of hardships can one ascend to become the master of others* (吃得苦中苦，方为人上人). Then why exactly must one become a "master of others"? Because within Chinese society, it is either you who are devoured, or I who am devoured; becoming a "master of others" is strictly for the purpose of feeding others to the beast while avoiding being devoured oneself.

However, within a **restoration-bureaucratic society**, fundamentally no lineage in the world can reap prolonged, enduring profits; even the emperor is compelled to live in perpetual, trembling terror, ultimately still unable to evade the day he himself is devoured. In China, it is phenomenally difficult to argue that even the lives of the imperial family possess any genuine meaning; apart from playing the role of cogs within the bureaucratic apparatus, they serve virtually zero other function. If one compares the dynastic lifespans during China's **restoration-bureaucratic period** (复辟官僚时期) against the protracted epochs experienced by those feudal dynasties in Europe and Japan, this point is naturally blatantly obvious.

Driven by the dread of being devoured by the Evil God themselves, people frantically slaughter their own compatriots like maniacs. Yet, from the perspective of an external observer, the Evil God fundamentally does not exist to begin with; those devouring humans are nothing more than humans themselves. If everyone ceased to believe that this Evil God genuinely existed, then mutual slaughter would constitute a completely unnecessary idiocy, and this mutually destructive cultic order (人人互害的教团) would perish. In reality, this closely resembles certain low-budget horror films universally prevalent in the modern world: a group of people, due to certain supernatural factors—such as unknown energies, anomalous magnetic fields, or hallucinogenic toxins—plunges into a collective hysteria (集体癡症), consequently perceiving each other as monsters and attacking one another.

Consequently, we have essentially perceived the shroud of mystery and terror cast over the "Grand Chinese Case." I maintain that the Ming (明) and Qing (清) empires had indeed evolved to such an extreme degree that the Chinese—a demographic cohort chronically constituting one-quarter of the global population—plunged into a collective hysteria (集体癡症) spanning several centuries. Their perception of the world existed within a bizarre hallucination, to the extent that, in the eyes of outsiders standing outside this hallucination, their behavioral manifestations had already drastically diverged from humanity.

This is exactly why I phenomenally admire Mr. Philip Alden Kuhn's (孔飞力) *Soulstealers* (《叫魂》). As a scholar, he undoubtedly possessed a genius-level intuition; by utilizing a highly cunning yet quintessential perspective through an outbreak of this exact collective hysteria, he physically touched its very existence.

Therefore, readers should naturally comprehend precisely why, when authoring this manuscript, I placed immense emphasis upon the classical China and the partially **feudalized** (封建化) China—namely, the eight centuries of history from the 2nd century BC to the 6th century AD. It is identically why I directed considerable attention toward the early **restoration-bureaucratic state** (前期复辟官僚国家)—namely, the nearly seven centuries of history spanning the Tang (唐) and Song (宋) dynasties. Conversely, it explains why I inclined toward merely skimming over the history of the late **restoration-bureaucratic state** (后期复辟官僚国家) from the Ming and Qing onwards.

This is not to imply that I believe research into Ming-Qing history lacks value (*naturally, as I stated previously, researching Ming-Qing history constitutes an emotionally agonizing and profoundly burdensome ordeal for contemporary Chinese individuals*). I shall employ a metaphor, and the readers will naturally comprehend. Suppose a highly malignant infectious disease with a mortality rate approaching 100% suddenly emerged in the world today. After its initial transmission captures global attention, everyone now knows that if a person contracts this disease, it is virtually impossible for them to survive. So, regarding the patient lying in the isolation ward of the hospital, should we simply abandon monitoring and treating the patient, wait for them to die, and then hastily dispose of the corpse? Obviously not. Although the patient has indeed stepped through the gates of hell (鬼门关), it does not mean we have zero need to comprehend the precise information regarding exactly how this disease kills humans.

To combat such a malignant disease, what humanity requires to know is not exclusively its mode of transmission, but identically its pathogenesis and lethal mechanisms. The historical exceptionality of the Chinese empire lies precisely in the fact that it serves as an astoundingly quintessential and colossal infection specimen. I wish to ask: as fellow human beings, which nation in the world today dares to assert with absolute certainty that it will definitively not encounter the identical catastrophic fate China once suffered? I fear there is none.

Therefore, the history of the Late Imperial Chinese empire (晚期中华帝国) naturally possesses monumental significance, and foreign scholars have already dedicated massive efforts toward this and achieved spectacular triumphs; nothing is more profoundly gratifying than such news.

However, precisely as I have articulated in this subsection, researching the late **restoration-bureaucratic society** (晚期复辟官僚社会) has already transcended general socio-historical issues. The influence of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚体制) had already permeated every conceivable dimension of the entire society ubiquitously, exactly like a virus that has metastasized throughout the entire physical body. Attempting to research this segment of history with absolute clarity inevitably necessitates the synergistic participation of numerous academic disciplines—such as social psychology—which is fundamentally impossible for any single individual or even a small team to accomplish. Consequently, I had no choice but to exercise extreme rhetorical caution when handling it, while eagerly anticipating the emergence of more research outcomes; I genuinely hope readers can comprehend this.

最后我想再谈谈这九百个日夜中我关于自己所看到的“中国大案”的感触。我认为中国历史所隐藏的这个惊天大案对于全人类的确是拥有很大价值的。这一方面是因为它的漫长、庞大、严重和隐蔽：在长达一千四百年的时间里，可能有三、四亿甚至更多受害者直接或间接因为复辟官僚制度死亡。他们有的死状极为惨烈，更多的人是在真空一般的寂静中死去，连一声呻吟也没有。对于绝大多数中国人而言，我们的生命几乎没有任何意义，从出生之日起就可以望见人生的尽头。中国的官僚复辟对于整个人类历史产生了关键的影响，直接改变了人类文明的整体发展格局。这场光天化日的行凶有过如此多的目击者：最初中国北方的游牧民族、朝鲜人、越南人和日本人，然后是印度人和穆斯林，在更晚的时候欧洲人到达了案发现场，最后出现的是美国人。这些目击者们有的自身也卷入了案件，有的明显发现了怪异之处，但它们最终都没有还原出案件的始末。

更重要的或许是这一重大历史事件的复杂性。美国知名汉学家孔飞力先生（Philip Alden Kuhn）有一部非常有名的作品《叫魂：1768年中国妖术大恐慌》，这本书在我看来视角是非常棒的。从我对中国历史的认识来看，如果说隋、唐、五代和宋这将近七个世纪间官僚复辟体制与封建主义进行拉锯并最终基本消灭后者的历史还主要是政治、经济和社会问题。那么等到明清帝国以来的六个世纪间，复辟官僚制度完全稳固，封建主义不再对其构成任何威胁，整个复辟官僚社会的发展就已经彻底陷入了一种诡谲的状态。人们既不知道复辟官僚制度是怎么诞生的，也完全不明白其存在到底有何意义，但是却因为它世代代生活在莫名的恐惧中，又不断地为它寻找存在的合法性。

如果我们把复辟官僚制度视为人类历史中的一个残忍的凶手，那么它究竟是什么模样呢？中国的最高统治者和官僚们是它吗？好像不是。官衙是它吗？好像也不是。社会意识是它吗？好像还不是。怪异的地方就在这里，我们明知道复辟官僚制度残害了数以亿计的百姓，但它到底是怎么动手杀人的？

我们打一个比方来解释这种现象。想象一下一个孤立的社会中普遍信仰某个邪神，这个邪神就是复辟官僚制度。在人们的潜意识中，这个邪神比任何人能所想到最邪恶的造物还恐怖，它依靠吃人维持存在。基于这样的观念，整个社会组织成一个高度等级化的邪教教团。人们想方设法让别人成为供奉给邪神的祭品，而使自己得以逃脱。在这个教团中地位越高，就有决定更多人成为祭品的权力，同时能让自己变成祭品的人也会少一些。实际上任何在中国社会生活过的人都不会忘记这一点。正如同中国的一句名言所说：吃得苦中苦，方为人上人。那么为什么要当“人上人”呢？因为在中国社会不是你被吃，就是我被吃，当人上人就是为了让别人被吃并且避免自己被吃。然而在复辟官僚社会，全世界没有任何家族能够长久获利，就算是皇帝也不得不胆战心惊，甚至依旧免不了被吃的一天。在中国，即使是皇族的生命也很难说有任何意义可言，他们除了扮演官僚系统的齿轮以外几乎没有什么别的功用。比较一下中国复辟官僚时期王朝的国祚和欧洲与日本那些封建王朝所经历的漫长岁月，这一点当然是显然的。

人们出于对邪神吃掉自己的担忧，发疯一样残害自己的同胞。可是站在一个外部观察者看来，邪神本就是不存在，吃人的无非是人罢了。如果人人都不认为这个邪神真的存在，那么自相残杀就是完全没有必要的蠢事，这种人人互害的教团便会消亡。实际上这就很像现在的世界上普遍存在的一些小成本恐怖片：一群人因为一些超自然的因素，比如说未知能量，奇异磁场和致幻毒素陷入了一种集体癡症，进而把彼此视为鬼怪相互攻击。

这样一来我们就多少看到了中国大案所蒙上了一层充满了神秘和恐怖的阴影。我认为明清帝国的确已经发展到了这样一种程度，中国人，这样一个长期占据世界人口四分之一的群体，陷入了持续数个世纪的集体癡症。他们对于世界的看法处在一种奇特的幻觉当中，以至于在不在这种幻觉中的外人看来其表现已经与人类有很大差别。这就是我为什么非常赞赏孔飞力先生的《叫魂》，他作为学者无疑拥有天才般的直觉，用一个既刁钻又典型的视角通过这种集体癡症的一次爆发触摸到了其存在。

因此读者应当也能够明白我为什么在写这份记录的时候非常看重古典的中国和一定封建化的中国，也就是公元前二世纪到公元六世纪这八百年的历史；比较关注前期复辟官僚国家，也就是唐宋将近七个世纪的历史；但是对于明清以来的后期复辟官僚国家的历史倾向于一笔带过。这并不是我认为明清史研究缺少价值（当然就如我之前说的，研究明清史对现在的中国人而言过于沉痛，在情感上负担很大），我打一个比方读者自然能明白。假如现在世界上出现了一种致死率接近100%的恶性传染病，在最初的传播被世界关注到之后，现在大家都知道一个人得上这种病几乎就不可能活了。那么对于在医院隔离区里的患者来说，难道我们就应该放弃对病人的监控和治疗等他死掉之后赶紧处理尸体吗？显然不是这样。尽管患者确实已经走到了鬼门关，但是不代表这种病怎么致人死亡的信息我们不需要了解。要想对抗这样一种恶疾，人类所需要知道的不仅是它的传播方式，同样也有它的发病和致死机理。中华帝国的历史

特殊就特殊它是一个如此典型和庞大的感染样本。我想问，大家同样为人，今天世界上哪个国家敢说自已一定不会遇到中国曾经遭遇的厄运？恐怕是没有的。因此晚期中华帝国的历史自然极有意义，而且外国学者对此已经付出了很多并且取得了极大成就，没有什么比这些消息更令人欣慰了。然而就像我在这一小节表明的，研究晚期复辟官僚社会已经超出了一般的社会历史问题，复辟官僚体制的影响已经无孔不入地出现在整个社会的所有方面，就如同病毒已经扩散到全身一样。要想把这段历史研究清楚必然需要很多学科的共同参与，例如社会心理学，这对于任何个人甚至一个小团队都不可能做到。我在处理的时候不得不谨言，并且期待更多的成果初现，希望读者能够理解。